



KRISHNA MURTHY

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PRABHAT SHANDILYA,
Founder, Magadh Jal Jamaat

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area, leading to a huge improvement in the crop yield. In 2007, the 11-km-long Vanshi Nallah was unclogged.

These days, Shandilya and his men are busy clearing up the 28-km-long water channel that runs from Chapardah to Thaneta village. Last heard, Shandilya was at Ismailpur, one of the villages in Gaya, where he and 50 other men were slugging it out under the scorching sun to clear the

two-km portion of a water channel of weeds that had been stopping the flow of the Jamune river—the solitary source of irrigation for 28 villages. Discussions on about their target. Watching able-bodied men struggling in neck-deep water clear the weeds is an extraordinary sight far cry from the days when the villagers used to approach the water agencies to solve their water problems only to be given a lip service. “The mental make-up has undergone a sea-change. Now the villagers work and the government agencies look on in awe,” says the bachelor, who is financially supported by the family business in cane furniture.

Today, the villagers of Gaya have agreed to let go of their mutual problems and focus towards the fulfilment of a united cause: conservation of water. And even if a trouble erupts, there is always Shandilya on bank on, soothing them, his voice soft and clear, yet persuasive and commanding—the voice of reason, of humanity.